Rookie Mistakes

First Jobs

1. What was your first job, and how did you get it?
2. How did you prepare for that job? What worried you the most back then?
3. Was it the money, the commute, the rent, or something else that mattered most?
4. Did your college major relate to your first job? What about your current job?
5. What did you think work would be like before your first day? Were you right?
6. Who helped you most in your first month, and what did they do?
7. What do you know now that you wish you had known then?

Starting Out

1. Do you feel safe in your workplace? Is it OK to make mistakes there?
2. How did you feel the first time you made a mistake at work?
3. Who do you turn to when you are stuck — a colleague, your manager, or a friend?
4. In your field, is it better to ask a question or to figure it out alone?
5. How does your company treat new hires in their first week?
6. What is one small thing that makes a new job easier?

Rookie Mistakes

1. What are some common rookie mistakes in your field?
2. Do new hires ask too many questions, or do they act like they know it all?
3. Do rookies sometimes over-explain everything they do? Why?
4. Why do new hires answer "yes" or "no" before they think?
5. Is oversharing personal information a problem at work? Have you seen it?
6. Is being too eager to impress a mistake? What can go wrong?
7. Which rookie mistake do you find the most forgivable, and why?

Mistakes and Consequences

1. Which mistakes are acceptable in a job, and which ones are not?
2. Can a small mistake ever cost a company a lot of money? Give an example.
3. When the mistake is your fault, should you speak up right away or fix it first?
4. How should a manager react when a new hire makes a mistake?
5. Is it worse to hide a mistake or to make one in the first place?
6. Do people learn more from their own mistakes or from other people's?

Learning from Mistakes

1. What was the very first mistake you made in your career? How did you fix it?
2. Did anyone help you fix it, or did you handle it alone?
3. Did you report it right away, or try to solve it yourself first?
4. Have you seen a newbie make the same mistake you once made? What did you do?
5. What is the biggest lesson a mistake has taught you?
6. How do you stop yourself from repeating the same mistake?
7. Is there a mistake you are still embarrassed about today?

Helping New Colleagues

1. If you were a senior mentor, how would you help rookies settle in?
2. What could your company do to make a new hire's first month easier?
3. Should a mentor step in early, or let a rookie learn the hard way?
4. How do you give feedback to a new colleague without hurting them?
5. What advice would you give someone starting in your field next week?
6. If a new hire asks you the same question twice, how do you react?